Captain's Guide

companion page for the Portion & Container Labels

Labels are the difference between "there's food in the fridge" and "dinner is the chicken soup, stovetop, six minutes, serves the kids tomorrow." Put a labeled container in front of anyone at 5 p.m. on a hard day and watch their shoulders drop in relief.

Run the labels like a tiny system

— Cut out a stack at the start of the train — keep them with the cooler and a marker. Ready-made kindness, loose in a drawer.

— Every label needs three answers: what is it, when was it made, and how do we bring it back to life. The reheating line matters even when it feels obvious to you; it's not obvious to a sleep-deprived person.

— The fridge / freeze / serve-today checkboxes are the family's daily triage. Encourage circling one even if it's just a slash of the pen.

Portions worth writing down

— "Serves 4 adults + 2 kid-sized" is a real sentence — write it where it fits. A family that knows the portion stops hoarding and stops worrying.

— Suggest family-style containers with lids over tiny ones: one dinner per container, one thought in their head instead of six.

Gentle gotchas

— Painter's tape on lids rescues volunteers who "didn't have labels" — tape writes on anything and comes off clean.

— Borrowed containers go home initially unlabeled but personally claimed. Add your initials so the good pot eventually travels back.

A label is a tiny love note written for a person at their most exhausted. Keep the marker with the labels, and you've handed the family a working dinner every single time.